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002A — Renaissance Crisis and Italian Humanism

Palmer & Colton reading guide · 2026–27

Sources: Palmer & Colton, A History of the Modern World, 8th ed., pp. 46–61; Ordinance of Labourers (England, 1349; followed by the 1351 Statute).

Historical correction source: Metropolitan Museum of Art, "Gothic Art": https://www.metmuseum.org/essays/gothic-art

Reading plan: No homework is due Monday October 5 because of Yom Tov. Begin P&C pp. 46–48 aloud together Monday and discuss the Black Death and labor source. Monday night, finish only the unread portion through p. 52. Tuesday completes crisis, Church authority, and representative institutions. P&C pp. 53–61 is Tuesday-night preparation for Wednesday; pp. 62–70 is Wednesday-night preparation for Thursday.

MEETING H002.1A — Monday 10/05 and Tuesday 10/06 | Crisis and periodization

AIM: How can crisis change society without creating a clean break with its past?

GOALS: Explain a crisis mechanism; read the labor source; defend a continuity/change judgment.

DO NOW (3 minutes) — CLOSED NOTE + SOURCE PREVIEW: Recall one limit on political power from The Prince. Then read the first sentence of the 1349 Ordinance of Labourers excerpt below and underline the phrase that tells able-bodied workers what they must do.

CLASS ROUTE: Monday, begin P&C pp. 46–48 together; use Question 1 for the plague and labor consequences, then the Ordinance of Labourers and Question 4. Tuesday, use the completed reading through p. 52 for Questions 2–3, the contributing factors, and the continuity/change judgment. Use the printed background as reference. Italian humanism begins Wednesday.

Lesson 1 — The Italian Renaissance

The Palmer & Colton reading questions follow the lesson.

LESSON 1

THE ITALIAN RENAISSANCE

INTRODUCTION

• When we use the word "Renaissance" in the context of history, we usually mean the " Italian Renaissance"-and that's going to be our focus. (Later on, we'll talk about the "Northern Renaissance.")

• The exact timing of some historical periods is ambiguous, especially if their beginning is not marked by big events like battles or peace treaties. Nonetheless, this course uses roughly 1375–1527 for the Italian Renaissance; period boundaries remain debated.

• The word "Renaissance" literally means "re-birth"-which begs the question: The Renaissance was a rebirth of what exactly?

• You may remember that Rome fell in 476. What followed was a period called the "Middle Ages" that lasted until the Renaissance.

• We will discuss some potential causes of the Renaissance, as well as ways that the Renaissance differed from the Middle Ages. For our purposes, it is critical to note that during this period, many of ancient Greece and Rome's most influential texts had been lost, if not forgotten.

This lesson corresponds to PC, pp. 46–62.

BEFORE THE RENAISSANCE

READING — Five contributing factors before the Renaissance

1. There was a crisis in the Roman Catholic Church throughout much of the 14th and 15th centuries:

A. There was corruption in the Church, including simony, nepotism, and the selling of indulgences.

B. There was a power struggle that led to the Great Schism of the Church, with two popes claiming authority—one in Rome and one in Avignon (1378–1417). This meant that the Church didn't provide the same sort of stability that it had before, and many people were looking elsewhere for meaning. Rather than relying solely on the Church for answers to life's central questions, there was a greater openness to cultural and intellectual answers than before.

2. The Bubonic Plague/Black Death (1348–1350) wiped out about one third of Europe and created economic, social, and political instability.

3. There was a discovery of Greek and Roman cultural artifacts. This included Petrarch's discovery of some of Cicero's lost letters in 1345. People were discovering new things like statues all the time, and Roman art was literally being discovered in the soil. This led to an appreciation of Greek and Roman culture that had diminished in previous centuries.

4. The invention of the printing press (c. 1436) and moveable type (c. 1450) allowed new ideas to be spread more easily. We'll talk about this more when we get to the Northern Renaissance.

5. The Fall of Constantinople to the Ottomans in 1453 marked the end of Christendom's ties to any remnants of the old Roman Empire. This led many Christian scholars to flee westward, bringing their ancient Greek and Roman texts with them. The reappearance of these texts in Western Europe sparked a newfound interest in learning the Greek language and studying Greek's ancient texts—which had been absent for centuries in the education of Western Europe.

Structured Notes — Five Factors That Helped Set Up the Renaissance

Use the cue column as your skeleton. During teacher review, record the most important fact(s) and the effect in short phrases. Do not transcribe sentences. If a detail is already in your Palmer & Colton reading, compress it rather than copy it.

CUE / TOPIC	YOUR NOTES
Church crisis — corruption + Great Schism	• Simony + Nepotism • Great Schism (2-3 Popes in 3 cities) • Trouble w/ French kings. • weakened
Black Death (1348–1350)	• reduced workers, added demand on hard labor & improved Peasant life
Recovery of classical texts / artifacts	Printing Press made transcribing much faster and made knowledge spread faster. • new interest in Classical texts.
Printing press + movable type	
Fall of Constantinople (1453)	

SYNTHESIS — Which factor most directly increased access to classical learning? Write one causal sentence:

WAS THERE ACTUALLY A RENAISSANCE?

Hybrid notes: record the argument, not the teacher's sentences. Use one phrase for continuity and one for change.

READING — Periodization: continuity and change

The Renaissance links the Middle Ages to the Modern Era, although it's important to keep in mind that there's no clear dividing line between the time periods. One era flows into the next, often in subtle and imperceptible ways. Then, when we look back, we realize that quite a lot has changed actually. Even major events like significant wars and technology break-throughs are rarely a bright line between periods.

Many of the ideas developed in the late Middle Ages flow into the Renaissance, and many of the Renaissance's ideas flow into the Modern Era. This raises questions over whether the "Renaissance" deserves to be categorized as its own historical period or is just the end of the Middle Ages. Either way, the real challenge is to consider how to periodize this long span of centuries in which people continued to think in new ways. Arguably, there was no Renaissance at all; in this view, what we see as the Renaissance was just a logical continuation of the Middle Ages. Perhaps we shouldn't even speak about a "Middle Ages" at all, but of the rise of Europe after the fall of the Western Roman Empire. In this view, Western Europe did its best with Latin and the limited Greek texts it had, but it was always thirsty for more Greek.

But despite all this, the term "Renaissance" can be very helpful in describing a shift that brought us to modernity, which clearly is different from what came before, and it did so through a reexamination of Greco-Roman culture - both by reemphasizing Greece over Rome, and by considering Greco-Roman culture in a new way - by looking at it through a Christian lens, producing a new secular culture in the process.

CUE / TOPIC	YOUR NOTES
Periodization problem — why no bright line?	b/c they are very close, don't have specific dates making it hard to get right
Continuity — what late-medieval developments carry forward?	the King in new ways while mixing western Europes love for Latin & Greek txt.
Change — what makes "Renaissance" a useful label?	b/c it means Rebirth. a Rebirth from old times.

ONE-SENTENCE JUDGMENT — Was the Renaissance more a rebirth, a continuation, or both? Use although / while.

I. Crisis before the Renaissance — P&C pp. 46–52

1. Black Death and labor. According to Palmer & Colton, identify two ways the plague changed work, wages, landholding, or relations between workers and landowners. For each, point to a specific detail from pp. 47–49.

2. Church authority. What events made the fourteenth-century papacy look less universal or less authoritative? Name two developments from pp. 49–52 and explain the effect of each.

3. Continuity and change. Palmer & Colton call the fifteenth century a "golden age" of medieval parliaments even while kings were trying to strengthen themselves. What pressure pushed rulers to bargain with representative bodies?

Primary source — Ordinance of Labourers (England, 1349; followed by the 1351 Statute)

That every man and woman of our kingdom of England, of whatever condition, whether bond or free, who is able bodied and below the age of sixty years, not living from trade nor carrying on a fixed craft, nor having of his own the means of living, or land of his own ... and not serving another, if he, considering his station, be sought after to serve in a suitable service, he shall be bound to serve him who has seen fit so to seek after him; and he shall take only the wages ... which ... were accustomed to be paid in the twentieth year of our reign of England [1346] ... And because many sound beggars do refuse to labour so long as they can live from begging alms, giving themselves up to idleness and sins, and, at times, to robbery and other crimes—let no one, under the aforesaid pain of imprisonment ... give anything to such as can very well labour ...

Excerpt with omissions marked; bracketed date supplied. Translation: Ernest F. Henderson (1896), via Yale Avalon

4. Source analysis. Identify two things the law orders people to do or not do. Then explain what post-plague labor problem the government appears to be trying to control. Use one phrase from the source and one fact from Palmer & Colton.

Able bodied People under 60 who dont work must accept offered work & Pre-Plagued wages. People cant give to healthy beggars, who are capable of working because of high labor to get cheap work & wage demand, Govt tried to find ways

WRITING PRACTICE — Write one sentence that states the post-plague change and its consequence. Use "because," "but," or "so" to make the causal relationship explicit.

english Peasants gained bargaining power & demanded higher pay b/c the Plague wiped out 1/3 of the labor force.

HOMEWORK — for Tuesday 10/06: Finish only the unread portion of P&C pp. 46–52. Prepare brief answers to Questions 2–3 from pp. 49–52. Do not begin pp. 53–61 yet.

HOMEWORK — for Wednesday 10/07: Read P&C pp. 53–61 (9 pages); mark Florence/patronage and classical learning. Bring 002A.